TOP SECRET

THE SECRETARY OF DEFENSE

WASHINGTON 25, D. C.

29 JUL 1950

Dear Mr. Secretary:

On 28 July the Joint Chiefs of Staff sent me the following memorandum on the defense of Formosa:

"1. It has been estimated that the Chinese Communists have the capability now of lifting 200,000 armed troops from the mainland to Formosa. In view of the numbers of craft available to the Communists, estimated to be as many as 4,000, the relatively short distances involved, the limited naval forces that can be made available to Commander, Seventh Fleet and their frequent employment in the Korean area, it appears that Communist craft and military personnel might reach the coast of Formosa in sufficient numbers to jeopardize seriously the political and military stability of the Nationalist Government and to cause major defection of its ground forces, and thus to cause the loss of Formosa.

"2. The Chinese Communists have announced their intention of capturing Formosa. It is understood to be the present opinion of the Secretary of State that should we fail successfully to defend Formosa, the international political repercussions would be so far-reaching as to be entirely out of proportion to the value of the island itself in our efforts to thwart the advancement of Communism.

"3. The Joint Chiefs of Staff consider that the successful accomplishment of the mission assigned to the Seventh Fleet and the denial of Formosa to the Communists is seriously hazarded by Chinese Communist capabilities. This unfortunate position can be corrected in part if the Chinese Nationalists can make timely efforts to defend Formosa.

"4. The Joint Chiefs of Staff therefore recommend that:

"a. The pertinent part of the President's statement of 27 June be so clarified as to permit the Nationalist Government to employ its military forces in defensive measures to prevent Communist amphibious concentrations directed against Formosa or the Pescadores. Such measures should include attacks on such concentrations and mining of those mainland water areas from which such an assault could be staged.

DECLASSIFIED
E.O. 12065, Sec. 3-402
State Dept. Guideline, June 12, 1979
By NLT-BLK NARS, Date 9-22-81
TS 2508

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"b. The Government of the United States inform the Nationalist Government that it is free to enhance the security of Formosa by the measures suggested."

The Joint Chiefs of Staff have subsequently informed me that, at their request, General MacArthur has forwarded his views on the above and that he concurs completely with the above recommendations.

I also concur in these recommendations. In view of the urgency of this matter from the military point of view, I propose that, if you agree, I present the foregoing as soon as possible to the President for his approval.

Sincerely yours,

The Honorable

The Secretary of State

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